Topology-Aware Mapping for Photonic Interconnects in TPU-Class LLM Accelerators

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***Abstract*—We evaluate co-packaged photonic interconnect—using the public Lightmatter Passage family (EVK50/EVK100/L200/L200X/M1000) as a concrete reference point—as an emerging technology for TPU-class accelerator clusters running large language model workloads. Because AccelForge does not natively model an inter-chip network, we add (i) a topology-aware network model with hop count, contention, multicast semantics, and conversion-plus-distance link energy; (ii) an iterative feedback loop that folds the network cost back into a logical cluster-memory level so that the AccelForge mapper sees network-augmented memory; and (iii) an explicit distributed-schedule layer above the mapper that enumerates XLA/GSPMD-style policies (sharded collective, remote pooled-HBM streaming, replicated cache, photonic multicast cache fill) and a 9216-chip Ironwood-class superpod stage model covering public Gemma 4 open-model proxies and Gemini-class stress proxies. Three insights stand out. First, the intra-chip mapping (partitioning, dataflow, tile sizing in the 6.5930 sense) is essentially invariant under photonics: 0/24 inner mapping signatures change in the TPU-cube study, while 5/16 distributed schedules change. The benefit therefore lives almost entirely in a layer that the AccelForge mapper does not see. Second, hardware multicast—not raw bandwidth—is the decisive property. M1000 still outperforms a strong 3.5 Tb/s, 6 pJ/bit chiplet baseline by 99.85% on shared-state multicast. Third, the technology is not a uniform multiplier. End-to-end inference reaches 42.43× latency speedup on the Gemma 4 26B MoE proxy and 14.50× on the longer-context Gemini stress proxy. Training improves less—3.37× on Gemma 4 MoE and 1.43× on the larger Gemini stress proxy—because once collectives are removed, larger training runs become compute-dominated.**

I. Background, Related Work, and Motivation

Modern LLM systems are no longer limited only by matrix multiply throughput. The hard part is moving activations, KV-cache state, expert tokens, gradients, optimizer state, and shared weights through a memory hierarchy that spans registers, on-chip buffers, HBM, and thousands of accelerator chips. This is why the project is framed as Project 12, "evaluate a new technology," rather than as a simple link replacement. The technology question is: if co-packaged photonic interconnect is inserted into a TPU-class cluster, does it only reduce the pJ/bit of an existing dataflow, or does it change the mapping, memory placement, compiler schedule, and topology that a large ML system should choose?

A. AccelForge and optimal accelerator mapping

AccelForge is the right base model because it treats accelerator evaluation as a mapping problem. In the class vocabulary, a mapping is not a vague schedule: it is the choice of partitioning, dataflow/stationarity, tile sizing, and storage residency across the memory hierarchy [2], [3]. The recent Turbo-Charged Mapper (TCM) paper sharpens that idea and is directly relevant to how we interpret our results. TCM argues that accelerator energy and latency depend on how computation and data movement are scheduled, and that heuristic mappers can make hardware comparisons misleading because they may miss the optimal mapping [5]. Its main addition is *dataplacement*: which tensor tiles are present at each memory level at a given time. In TCM's terminology, dataplacement, dataflow, and tile shape together define the mapspace; for a GPT-3 attention example, the paper reports a space with 16 dataplacements, roughly 10^{15} dataflows, and 10^{22} tile-shape choices, then prunes redundant and dominated choices by up to 32 orders of magnitude [5]. It also reports optimal searches in feasible runtime and large EDP improvements over prior heuristic or metaheuristic searches [5].

This matters for our project in two ways. First, we should not claim that a new interconnect helps unless we give the mapper an opportunity to respond. Second, if the AccelForge mapping does *not* move, that is still a meaningful result: it says the local GEMM partitioning/dataflow/tile choice is dominated by per-chip compute and local memory reuse, not by the fabric. Our method therefore exposes a new logical memory level to AccelForge, feeds network cost back into that level, and separately models the compiler-level distributed schedule that AccelForge does not yet represent.

B. Google TPU clustering as the target architecture

Google TPUs are the natural hardware target because their public architecture already makes clustering a first-order design problem. TPU v5p and TPU7x/Ironwood use high-speed inter-chip interconnect (ICI), and TPU7x slices larger than 64 chips are constructed from one or more $4\times4\times4$ cubes [14], [15]. A full TPU7x pod is documented at 9216 chips, with 2307 BF16 TFLOP/s and 4614 FP8 TFLOP/s per chip, 192 GiB HBM per chip, 7380 GiB/s HBM bandwidth, and 1200 GB/s bidirectional ICI per chip [15]. Google also describes Ironwood as a system designed for large inference workloads and as part of a co-designed AI stack around hardware, XLA, and cluster management [16], [17].

Those facts shape the evaluation. The $4\times4\times4$ TPU cube is the smallest realistic topology unit; the 9216-chip pod

is the scaling target; and compiler-visible sharding matters because TensorFlow/JAX/XLA and PyTorch/XLA already present users with a logical device abstraction and lower sharding annotations into collectives [18]. Our report therefore treats the TPU fabric as a memory-system problem, not as a black-box bandwidth number. Node-to-node traffic corresponds to sharded activation or collective-permute-like exchange; node-to-DRAM traffic corresponds to remote HBM, KV, or optimizer-state fetch; shared-DRAM multicast corresponds to cache-fill or weight/expert broadcast.

C. Photonics and topology choices for future ML systems

Photonics is relevant because future ML systems are becoming both larger and more topologically sensitive. Electrical links work well for short nearest-neighbor traffic, but a torus pays repeated hop and fanout cost when data must cross a cube or broadcast to many chips. Lightmatter's Passage family gives public points for the kind of optical fabric we want to study. EVK100 is listed as a 3.2 Tb/s aggregate link with 1.6 Tb/s unidirectional single-fiber transmission and a conservative 3.2 pJ/bit target at 112G PAM4 [9]; the broader Passage family also reports a 1.9 pJ/bit reference point used here as a sensitivity case [8]. M1000 is listed at 114.6 Tb/s aggregate bidirectional bandwidth and 2.3 pJ/bit including laser power [11]. Lightmatter also frames 3-D photonic interconnect as a way around the chip "shoreline" limit: electrical I/O exits through the package edge, whereas a photonic interposer can expose far more communication through the chip surface [11]. The L200 family and OCP co-packaged optics material provide additional public references for switched optical fabrics [10], [12], [13].

The architectural implication is that photonics is not just a better wire. It changes the topology design space. A TPU-style system could remain a torus with lower-energy optical links, but it could also become a flatter switched fabric with hardware multicast, pooled remote HBM, and different compiler placement choices. CiMLoop for Photonics models photonic DNN accelerators at the component and per-accelerator level [6]; our project is complementary because it keeps each chip's compute/memory hierarchy fixed and asks how the inter-chip fabric changes the cluster-scale mapping and schedule.

D. Project question and contributions

The report therefore studies whether Lightmatter-style photonics is a constant-factor link substitution or a system-level change in how LLM workloads should be mapped and scheduled. Three findings summarize the answer.

1) **The intra-chip mapping is stable; the distributed schedule changes.** For the 64-chip TPU cube, the AccelForge mapper converges to the same partitioning/dataflow/tile signature for all modeled cube interconnect variants (0/24 inner signatures change). The benefit lives one layer above: the optimal distributed communication pattern flips for 5 of 16 workload–scenario pairs, and the optimal compiler-visible schedule changes whenever multicast becomes available.

TABLE I: How the report uses 6.5930 concepts.

Class concept	Use in this project
Data motion dominates	Network, HBM, UB, register, and MAC energy are kept separate so the result can say which level moves the joules.
Memory hierarchy	`LogicalClusterMemory` sits above per-chip HBM; its cost is updated with network energy/latency.
Mapping	AccelForge reports partitioning, stationarity/dataflow, tile sizing, and storage residency for each GEMM proxy.
Dataflow vs. schedule	Intra-chip dataflow is the mapper's stationarity choice; the distributed schedule is a compiler-level choice above AccelForge.
Calculating motion	Logical-memory action counts are converted to bits, then priced by topology, hop count, contention, and multicast semantics.
Advanced technology	Photonics is evaluated as a system change in the L11 sense [4]: link energy, topology, multicast, pooled HBM, and compiler-visible locality.

2) **Hardware multicast, not raw bandwidth, dominates shared-state workloads.** A 3.5 Tb/s, 6 pJ/bit chiplet baseline is still beaten by M1000 by 99.85% on shared-DRAM multicast traffic, because N unicasts collapse into one logical broadcast. The same chiplet baseline is competitive on node-to-node activation exchange.
3) **Photonics is not a uniform multiplier.** On a 9216-chip Ironwood-class superpod, the Gemma 4 26B MoE proxy reaches 42.43× inference latency speedup, while the larger long-context Gemini stress proxy reaches 14.50×. Training improves less: 3.37× for Gemma 4 MoE and 1.43× for the larger stress proxy. Once collectives shrink, training becomes compute-dominated; inference stays network-exposed because decode, KV attention, and MoE routing cross the fabric every step.

What is novel here is the combination: AccelForge's inner mapper, a topology cost model with multicast semantics and physical distance, an enumeration of compiler-visible distributed schedules, strong and weak scaling analysis, OCS/OPS switching sensitivity, and a 9216-chip stage-level superpod model are tied together into one reproducible evaluation.

II. Network-Aware Architecture and Initial Tests

A. Connection to class concepts

The project is deliberately organized around the course vocabulary: data movement dominates energy; memory hierarchy and locality control reuse; mapping separates partitioning, dataflow, placement, and tile sizing; and advanced technologies should be evaluated through the changes they induce in the architecture model, not only through a single headline device metric. Table I gives the concrete mapping from those concepts to the implementation.

B. Modeling stack: four layers

A central source of confusion when evaluating new interconnects is the word "mapping." We separate the pipeline into four explicit layers, only the first three of which live inside AccelForge.

(1) Workload (einsum). `workload/single_matmul.yaml` expresses $O_{m,n} = \sum_k A_{m,k} W_{k,n}$ with rank sizes (M, K, N) chosen per LLM stage (decode MLP, KV attention, prefill projection, long-context prefill, MoE dispatch, weight-gradient).

(2) Architecture. `arch/tpu_lightmatter_cluster.yaml` declares `!Memory`, `!Container`, and `!Compute` nodes: `LogicalClusterMemory` (the cluster-wide pool whose energy/latency we update from the network model), the `NodeArray` fanout (`NodeX`/`NodeY`/`NodeZ`), per-chip `HBM` (modeled at 7.03 pJ/bit per TPU v5p [14]), `UnifiedBuffer`, the `ProcessingElement` fanout with `reuse_input`/`reuse_output`, a weight `Register`, and the `MAC`.

(3) Mapping (AccelForge mapper output). For a fixed workload and architecture, AccelForge enumerates valid `!Storage`/`!Temporal`/`!Spatial`/`!Compute` sequences. A mapping therefore specifies, per loop variable, tile shape, temporal-vs-spatial binding, and which fanout/storage level it binds to. This is exactly the 6.5930 mapping formalism [2], [3]: partitioning, dataflow (stationarity), and tile sizing. Our `mapping_signature` encodes the spatial fanout assignments, memory residency, and action counts that distinguish two mappings.

(4) Distributed schedule (above AccelForge). AccelForge has no concept of how data moves *between* cluster nodes. We add three constructs above it: a `COMM_PATTERN` parameter that selects which tensor is resident in `LogicalClusterMemory` versus per-chip `HBM` (so the mapper sees a different architecture per pattern); the topology cost model of Sec. II-C; and a discrete enumeration of named XLA/GSPMD-style schedules: `xla_spmd_collective`, `remote_hbm_streaming`, `replicated_hbm_cache`, `photonic_multicast_cache`. The mapper does not pick among these; we evaluate each analytically and report the best.

When this paper says "dataflow," we mean the intra-PE stationarity pattern in the class sense. When we say "distributed dataflow strategy" or "compiler schedule," we mean the layer-4 inter-chip communication policy. These are different and we report them separately.

C. Topology cost model

For traffic of B bits over a topology with average hop count h, average link length $l(N)$, conversion energy e_c, transmission energy $e_{tx/mm}$, router latency t_r, and link bandwidth BW_ℓ:

$$E_{\text{net}} = B\left(e_c + h\, l(N)\, e_{tx/mm}\right),$$

$$T_{\text{net}} = \frac{B}{BW_\ell / C(N)} + h \cdot t_r + h\, l(N)\, t_{\text{prop/mm}} + t_{\text{switch}},$$

where $C(N)$ is the contention factor: $C(N) = \sqrt{N}$ for a 2-D mesh, $\sqrt[3]{N}$ for a 3-D torus, and 1 for an optical crossbar/switched fabric. Electrical and chiplet links are modeled with low conversion cost and distance-dependent transmission cost; photonic links are modeled as conversion/SerDes/laser dominated, with very small distance-dependent transmission. Multicast semantics also matter: a non-multicast technology pays the unicast volume N times for an N-way fanout, while a multicast-capable photonic technology pays only the unique payload once. This is why a flat switched optical fabric can deliver gains far beyond what its raw bandwidth ratio would predict.

D. Iterative feedback loop (M1, M2, M3)

AccelForge has no first-class NoC primitive between two storage levels. Rather than fake the inter-chip ICI as an opaque `!Memory`, we keep the network model explicit and feed it back into `LogicalClusterMemory`:

1) Run AccelForge with the current logical-memory energy and latency.
2) Extract logical-memory read/write traffic from the best mapping.
3) Evaluate the topology cost ($E_{\text{net}}, T_{\text{net}}$).
4) Add the per-bit network cost to `LOGICAL_READ_ENERGY`/`LOGICAL_WRITE_ENERGY` and matching latencies.
5) Re-run the mapper until the energy and signature stabilize.

This realizes Milestones M1 (topology + logical-memory model), M2 (iterative feedback), and M3 (improved topology proposal: EVK100 optical crossbar and M1000 switched fabric) in one loop.

E. Initial 16-node cluster tests

The first experiment is deliberately small: a 16-node cluster with the same accelerator node and workload, comparing an electrical 4×4 mesh against an EVK100-class optical crossbar. The goal is not to claim a final TPU result; it is to check whether the model responds to the right traffic patterns. We test three cases. In `node_to_node`, activations move between neighboring nodes. In `node_to_dram`, one node fetches remote state through the logical cluster memory. In `shared_dram_multicast`, one payload fans out to many nodes, representing shared weight, expert, or KV-cache fill.

This small test already shows the intended asymmetry. Node-to-node traffic gains little because the electrical mesh is already close to the data and the transfer can often hide behind compute. Remote and multicast traffic benefit much more: the best 16-node EVK100 cases reduce energy by 71.95% and latency by 97.57%. This is the sanity check for the rest of the report. Photonics should not be sold as a universal multiplier; it should help most when memory placement and fanout dominate the cost.

III. Scaling to TPU Cubes, Compiler Policies, and Superpod Workloads

A. Scaling path

After the 16-node sanity check, we increase the model in four steps. First, we replace the logical cluster with a TPU-style $4\times4\times4$ cube and compare electrical torus ICI against

TABLE II: Modeled interconnect technologies. Bandwidth is per-link one-way unless noted. Sources cited in Sec. I.

Technology	BW	Energy	MC	Role
Electrical 800G	0.8 Tb/s	10.0 pJ/bit	—	Electrical ICI baseline
Advanced chiplet	3.5 Tb/s	6.0 pJ/bit	—	Strong packaging baseline
Lightmatter EVK50	0.8 Tb/s	4.6 pJ/bit	yes	SC25 demo [7]
Lightmatter EVK100	3.2 Tb/s	3.2/1.9 pJ/bit	yes	Conservative / sensitivity
Lightmatter L200	16 Tb/s	4.5 pJ/bit	yes	Switched fabric [10]
Lightmatter L200X	32 Tb/s	4.8 pJ/bit	yes	High-BW switched fabric [13]
Lightmatter M1000	57.3 Tb/s	2.3 pJ/bit	yes	OCS full-stack study
M1000 OPS sensitivity	57.3 Tb/s	2.9 pJ/bit	yes	Analytical packet-switching point

photonic torus and switched-fabric variants. Second, we ask whether the best `COMM_PATTERN` changes when the cube is priced with photonic costs. Third, we add the compiler-visible schedule layer: conventional sharded collectives, remote pooled-HBM streaming, replicated HBM caching, and photonic multicast cache fill. Fourth, we sweep from one cube toward the 9216-chip pod and compare against a stronger advanced-chiplet baseline. This sequence keeps the model auditable: each larger experiment adds exactly one modeling idea on top of the previous one.

B. Superpod stage model

For the 9216-chip end-to-end study each LLM stage decomposes into

$$T_{\text{stage}} = \max(T_{\text{compute}}, T_{\text{HBM}}) + (1 - \alpha_{\text{ovl}})\, T_{\text{net}},$$
$$E_{\text{stage}} = E_{\text{compute}} + E_{\text{HBM}} + E_{\text{net}}.$$

The overlap factor $\alpha_{\text{ovl}} \in [0, 1]$ models how much network transfer is hidden behind compute and HBM. Modeled stages include prefill, decode KV attention, decode weight/expert refill, inference MoE dispatch/combine, training forward/backward, gradient synchronization, training MoE traffic, and optimizer-state traffic.

C. Experiment setup

Constants held fixed. All comparisons keep compute (MAC array, register, UB), per-chip HBM, and HBM energy/latency identical. Only interconnect technology, topology, and distributed schedule change. Table II lists the modeled technologies.

Baselines. The 16-node experiment uses an electrical 4×4 mesh; the 64-chip TPU cube uses a $4\times4\times4$ electrical torus (TPU v5p-class [14]); the superpod uses an Ironwood electrical torus (9216 chips, 4614 FP8 TFLOP/s per chip, 192 GiB HBM, 7.4 TB/s HBM bandwidth, 1200 GB/s bidirectional ICI per chip [15]). The advanced chiplet baseline (3.5 Tb/s, 6 pJ/bit) is included to rule out raw bandwidth as the only explanation for photonic gains.

Workloads. AccelForge experiments use six GEMM proxies for LLM stages: decode MLP, KV attention, prefill projection, long-context prefill, MoE dispatch, and training weight-gradient. The superpod study includes public Gemma 4 open-model proxies (26B MoE and 31B dense, with long context) and Gemini-class stress proxies: dense Flash, sparse MoE Pro, and long-context Deep Think [19]–[21]. The Gemma 4 sizes are public; the Gemini proxies are stress points, not claims about undisclosed Gemini 3/3.1 internals.

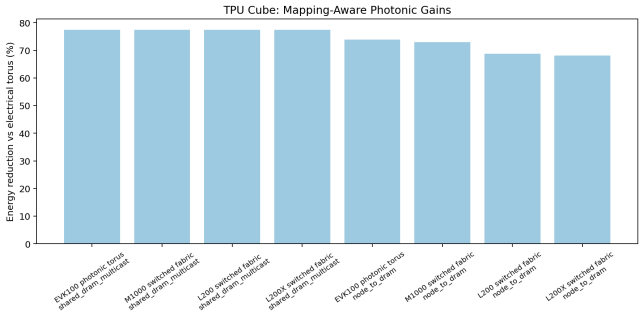


Fig. 1: TPU-cube AccelForge results. Energy and latency reductions for EVK100/L200/L200X/M1000 versus the $4\times4\times4$ electrical torus, by communication scenario. Multicast benefits the most; node-to-node exchange benefits least.

TABLE III: Headline results across the five evaluation axes.

Axis	Metric	Value	Where
16-node cluster	Energy red.	71.95%	EVK100 multicast
16-node cluster	Latency red.	97.57%	EVK100 multicast
TPU-cube net	Energy red.	99.93%	EVK100 multicast
TPU-cube map	Energy red.	77.45%	EVK100 KV attn
Inner mapping	Changed	0/24	TPU cube
Distributed map	Changed	5/16	cluster
Compiler sched.	Best gain	73.86%	EVK100 stream
Scaling law	Best slope	0.00	M1000 multicast
Chiplet vs M1000	Energy red.	99.85%	multicast
Superpod inf.	Speedup	42.43×	Gemma 4 MoE
Superpod train.	Speedup	3.37×	Gemma 4 MoE
Gemini stress inf.	Speedup	14.50×	Deep Think

Reproducibility. All experiments run inside the `accelforge:latest-amd64` Docker image via `make study/notebook/test`. The unit/integration suite verifies the technology catalog, network model, distance physics, mapper loop, artifact writers, strong/weak scaling, OCS/OPS sensitivity, and superpod summaries. CSV results and twelve presentation-ready figures are written under `results/`.

Threats to bias. (i) Lightmatter values are public headline numbers, so we modeled the architecture rather than a particular product, and verified key constants against multiple public sources; (ii) optical multicast is modeled optimistically as one logical broadcast, neglecting laser sharing and switch reconfiguration; (iii) the OCS/OPS comparison is a sensitivity study and not a claim that Lightmatter has announced an optical packet-switching product; (iv) the superpod stage model is analytical, not cycle-accurate; (v) Gemini parameter counts are unpublished, so we used proxy workloads.

IV. Results and Discussion

A. The inner mapping is stable; the schedule changes

The most surprising finding is the cleanly two-layered behavior of photonics. Across 24 (workload, technology, scenario) combinations on the 64-chip cube, the AccelForge mapper converges to the same spatial fanout, residency, and action-

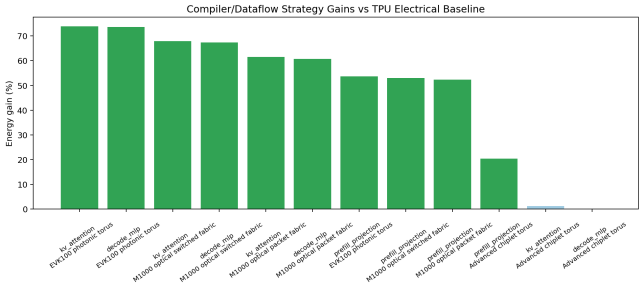


Fig. 2: Best XLA/GSPMD-style schedule per workload and technology. Color-marked cases (e.g., M1000 KV attention) are where the optimal compiler-visible policy changes versus the electrical baseline.

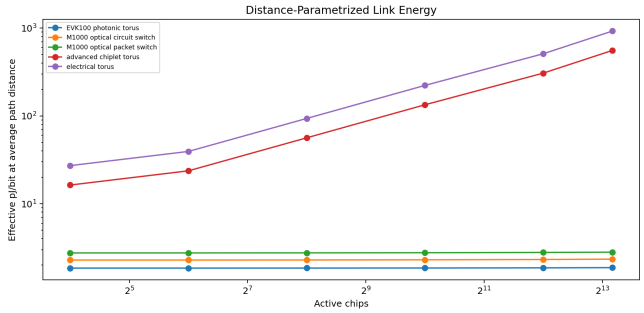


Fig. 3: Distance-parametrized link energy. Electrical/chiplet costs rise with modeled average path distance; photonic costs are conversion dominated and nearly flat.

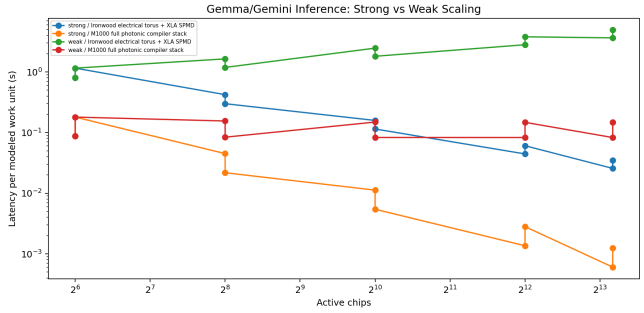


Fig. 4: Strong and weak inference scaling. The photonic full stack keeps per-work-unit latency lower as active chips grow.

count signature for all photonic and chiplet variants—0 of 24 inner mappings change. This is consistent with what we expect from class theory: the per-chip loop nest is dominated by local compute and SRAM/HBM reuse [1]–[3], and photonics does not change those costs.

The benefit instead lives in two distinct layer-4 places. **Distributed mapping (`COMM_PATTERN`).** For 5 of 16 workload–scenario pairs, the optimal communication pattern flips from node-to-node exchange to shared-DRAM multicast under EVK100 or M1000, because the multicast volume cost has collapsed. **Compiler schedule.** Among the four enumerated XLA/GSPMD-style policies, the best policy switches whenever multicast becomes available: `photonic_multicast_cache` dominates for shared-state KV/expert refill, and `remote_hbm_streaming` becomes attractive for KV attention with a 73.86% gain on EVK100 and a 67.94% gain on M1000 versus the baseline policy.

This separation is not a modeling limitation; it is the actual answer to "does photonics change the mapping?"—the mapping is stable, the schedule changes, and reporting them as one number would obscure both. Fig. 2 visualizes the schedule changes.

B. Multicast, not bandwidth, is decisive

The advanced chiplet baseline (3.5 Tb/s, 6 pJ/bit) was chosen specifically to defeat the "photonics just has more bandwidth" hypothesis. On node-to-node activation exchange the chiplet baseline is in fact close to EVK100. On shared-DRAM multicast the chiplet baseline is beaten by M1000 by 99.85%, because N unicasts collapse to one logical broadcast and contention disappears on a switched fabric. This isolates hardware multicast as the architectural property that matters most for shared-state LLM workloads (cache fills, expert refill, weight broadcast). The flat multicast scaling exponent (0.00 across the 64-to-9216-chip sweep) makes the same point geometrically: torus and chiplet fabrics accumulate hop and contention cost as N grows; switched optical multicast does not.

C. Distance, scaling mode, and optical switching semantics

The revised model also removes a hidden simplification in the first version of the project: electrical and photonic links should not both be modeled as flat pJ/bit constants. Electrical links have little conversion overhead but pay distance-dependent transmission loss; photonic links pay conversion/SerDes/laser overhead but very little incremental distance energy. Fig. 3 shows this directly. At small scale the difference is modest; near superpod scale the electrical and chiplet curves rise with average path length and hop count, while M1000 remains nearly flat for multicast traffic.

The same logic changes how we interpret scaling. In strong scaling, more chips are applied to a fixed modeled request or training step, so Amdahl-style compute/HBM limits show up quickly. In weak scaling, aggregate tokens increase with chip count, so the question is whether per-work-unit cost remains bounded as the system grows. Photonics is most valuable in the weak-scaling and long-context regimes, where additional concurrency and context create more shared-state traffic. Finally, the OCS/OPS sensitivity separates two optical design assumptions: OCS is best for bulk cache fill and multicast; the OPS point is a what-if model for fine-grained dynamic communication. It is not treated as a Lightmatter product claim.

D. Inference vs. training: not a uniform multiplier

Fig. 5 shows the end-to-end stage-decomposed result. On the 9216-chip Ironwood-class superpod, the Gemma 4 26B MoE proxy reaches 42.43× inference latency speedup with the full M1000 photonic stack because its active-parameter footprint makes decode, cache fill, and MoE traffic highly

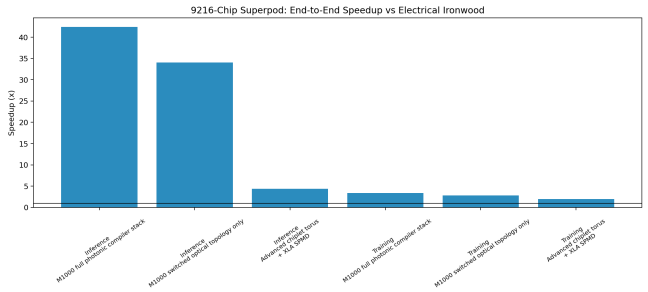


Fig. 5: End-to-end superpod speedups. Inference benefits much more than training; long-context inference benefits most.

network exposed. The larger long-context Gemini stress proxy still reaches 14.50×. Training improves less: 3.37× on Gemma 4 MoE and 1.43× on the larger stress proxy. The reason is exactly what the stage model predicts: once collectives, MoE dispatch, and KV broadcast traffic are removed, training becomes compute-dominated—it spends most of its critical path inside $\max(T_{\text{compute}}, T_{\text{HBM}})$, a term photonics does not change. Inference, especially long-context inference, remains network-exposed because decode is autoregressive and KV/expert traffic must move every step. This is a positive prediction: future TPU-class designs that pursue photonics for training payoff alone will under-perform expectations; the strong case for photonics is inference, long-context serving, and MoE/cache-heavy phases.

E. Where the approach helps and where it does not

Beneficial. (a) Long-context inference, where decode and KV-attention traffic dominate the critical path. (b) Sparse-MoE serving, where expert-parallel all-to-all traffic is network-bound. (c) Pooled remote HBM access, where flat fabrics make remote streaming competitive with replication. (d) Cache-fill / weight-broadcast traffic, which exploits hardware multicast directly.

Not beneficial. (a) Local nearest-neighbor activation exchange, where electrical torus is already efficient (one hop). (b) Compute-dominated training stages, where $\max(T_{\text{compute}}, T_{\text{HBM}})$ dominates. (c) Workloads whose tile mapping is already optimal under the electrical baseline—photonics does not change those mappings.

Limitations and future work. The optical multicast model is optimistic; a more detailed model would account for switch reconfiguration, laser sharing, and wavelength conflicts. The superpod stage model is analytical and uses an overlap factor; cycle-accurate simulation would tighten the inference numbers. The distributed-schedule enumeration is discrete; a continuous compiler search (e.g., direct XLA integration) is the natural next step. The Gemma 4 anchors and Gemini-class proxy workloads bound real behavior but do not claim exact correspondence.

What worked vs. what did not. Worked: the iterative-feedback loop converged in ≤ 3 iterations on every case; the topology model produced the predicted multicast asymmetries; the superpod stage model reproduced the inference-vs-training divergence cleanly. Did not work: trying to make AccelForge model the inter-chip NoC directly via a degenerate `!Memory` produced opaque, hard-to-debug numbers; we kept the network model external instead. The inner mapping signature did *not* change under any photonic technology—an honest negative result that we report rather than hide.

Future work. Direct XLA/Pallas integration; a cycle-accurate optical-switch simulator; co-design of MoE expert placement under photonic locality; extending the stage model to training with pipeline parallelism and ZeRO-3 optimizer sharding.

V. Reproducibility and Submission Checklist

The submitted artifact is intended to be read in two ways. First, it is a class project report: the paper, poster, and slide deck explain the problem, the accelerator abstraction, the network equations, the mapping results, and the limitations using the vocabulary of 6.5930. Second, it is an executable study: the repository contains the AccelForge architecture file, the workload template, the network and superpod analysis script, the notebook, and the regression tests needed to reproduce the tables and figures.

The public technology constants in the model are cross-checked against the cited primary sources. The class-specific pieces are kept explicit: AccelForge supplies the einsum-to-memory-hierarchy mapping, the project adds the logical-memory and topology-cost feedback loop, and the distributed schedule layer captures compiler-visible choices above the local tile mapping. All headline results in Table III are regenerated by `make study`; `make notebook` rebuilds and executes the notebook; `make deliverables` compiles the report, slide deck, poster, and summary sheet; and `make test` runs the regression suite. The checked results therefore come from the same code path as the submission PDFs rather than from manually edited tables.

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